

chip designing.

Satya comments, “Chip design is an extremely difficult process, and one mistake can cost you millions. Making it work after months of pouring in your sweat and tears is so satisfying. You have to live and breathe silicon. Which is why I say that silicon runs in my blood.”

But with his arrival in India, something bigger was waiting for Satya.

Beginning to startups

After toiling for years for the IME, in 2003, Intel decided not to pursue ASICs business. Satya saw this as a chance to do something more, out of the bounds of being tied to a corporation. “We built a beautiful model to build ASICs and we used to call it an Open-Model of chip design. So, we deliberated and decided to do this independently.”

And thus, despite having all the abilities to move up the ladder of professional success at Intel, Satya decided to leave as Director from the corporation—a place where he had his first and last corporate job. On being asked why he chose the tough road of startup and leaving a comfortable position at the world’s biggest MNC, Satya says that it was his desire to build something from scratch, much like the carpentry he adored in his childhood.

He says, “I wanted to do something in India for India.” But most importantly, like a true leader, he wanted to build a team and see them grow. “Seeing them become a VP or a Director gives immense satisfaction, telling me that we did something right because of which



Dr Satya Gupta receiving Open-Silicon GSA Award

so many people are growing in the industry.”

With this in mind, Satya started his first venture—OpenSilicon—along with Naveed Sherwani. While Naveed was in Portland, Satya was in India. They now had to make a commitment.

“We knew that if we wanted it to take off, we’d have to start in the Silicon Valley. We packed bags and decided to give us three months to find funding, otherwise we would go back and find new jobs.” During this time, they spent nights at hotels for \$30 a night and ate meals for 1.5 dollars, just to save every penny they had and put it into their company. Luckily for both the co-founders, they succeeded in bagging funding from some of the top VCs, Sequoia Capital, Norwest Venture Partners, and Goldman Sachs, in just two months of setting up shop in the USA.

But for a person who just escaped the constraints of working in a large corporation, the reality of building a startup with their own resources soon started to catch up. He says, “When you work in an MNC, you tend

to take a lot of things for granted. Even things like HR, finance and infrastructure become a big deal to take care of when you are building a startup. Money also has to be spent judiciously since it is not company funds anymore, but your own money or funds.”

One space where Satya made sure OpenSilicon strived for the best was the team. Onboarding not just the big shots in the industry, Satya wanted to get people who had the zeal and drive to make something happen. He opines, “In a startup, you have to get employees motivated to work.”

Channelising the teacher in him who taught peers in college, Satya imbibed it into his team building and leadership style. He would sit down to tape-out chips along with his team, despite being the co-founder of the company. “You need to sit down with them and get down to business. Work in the trenches with them as a team member instead of supervising them as a manager because that is not going to motivate your team. Sitting down with them makes the biggest difference instead of a few lofty words. It builds a bond that shows in the work.”

This zeal to build the team also

Top-5 Professional Moments

1. Receiving Best Semiconductor Company award from Global Semiconductor Association (GSA) for Open-Silicon
2. Receiving IEEE Gordon Bell award for breaking tera-flop barrier first time and the fastest supercomputer at Intel
3. Completing 150 tape-outs and shipping first ten million
4. Open-Silicon acquisition for \$245 million
5. Foundation of India Electronics & Semiconductor Association